



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Vanguard School

School Website: <https://thevanguardschool.com/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

The Vanguard School (Colorado Springs, CO, 80905) (Colorado Springs) presents a clearly classical orientation in its public materials. The curriculum centers on a classical liberal arts framework, Latin study, and a course of study that aligns with great-books tendencies and a traditional, character-formation emphasis. Public materials emphasize virtue, character development, and leadership, and they describe an academically rigorous program designed to prepare students for college within a classical paradigm. Parental involvement is actively encouraged, and the faculty are portrayed as virtuous mentors and living exemplars in a community that values discipline and civility. While the school foregrounds classical aims in curriculum, pedagogy, and community life, explicit theological or liturgical foundations are not prominently stated in the publicly available materials.

Overall classification (based on the Six Essential Elements rubric): CLASSICAL. The strongest alignments are in Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with notable, but less explicit, alignment in Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and Pedagogy. The School Purpose/Goal and Curriculum demonstrate robust classical aims; Pedagogy shows classical practices alongside some modern approaches; Faculty and Community are clearly oriented toward a classical, virtue-centric model.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The public materials foreground virtue, character, and moral formation as central to education (e.g., "culture is one of excellence in virtue, academics, leadership, and civics"; "development of their character and academic potential").
- The school emphasizes a classical liberal arts framework and character formation, but does not make explicit theological foundations or liturgical practices in public-facing pages (no explicit theology, liturgy, or worship programs are described) .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: virtue, character, moral formation, moral imagination, ethical education (present in mission and culture statements).
- Negative: theology, liturgy, sacred/chapel language not present in the public materials (i.e., lack explicit theological or liturgical references).
- Why this rating
- The school foregrounds moral formation and virtuous character, which aligns with transcendental moral realism, but there is no explicit theological grounding or liturgical practice described in the public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for this category rather than CLASSICAL, given the missing explicit theological/metaphysical anchors.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Mission emphasizes guiding students in character and academic potential, with an emphasis on virtue and leadership as core outcomes, and a culture of excellence in virtue and civics.
- Language and framing consistently position formation of character and moral formation as central aims, rather than narrow workforce preparation alone; the school frames education as forming the person (virtue, leadership, civics) within a classical framework.
- Curriculum and program descriptions tie Classical aims to college-preparatory performance, indicating formation with a traditional educational telos that includes liberal-arts grounding and moral development.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, classical mission (embedded in mission and culture language).
- Negative: explicit job/workforce-readiness framing (the site emphasizes formation and virtue over narrow job-schooling rhetoric); no overt negative indicators present in core public materials.
- Why this rating
- The school explicitly frames its purpose around character formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, aligned with classical paideia ideals, even as it also prepares for college. This combination justifies CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Vanguard School explicitly uses a classical, liberal arts curriculum and notes alignment with Hillsdale Academy Model; emphasis on a broad, classical grounding (English, math, history, science, world languages including Latin) and a history-forward, literature-rich approach.
- Elementary and secondary programs emphasize Latin, classical literature, and a “great books” orientation (e.g., Honors The Classical World; Latin I–V; classic literature in grade bands) .
- Public materials describe core knowledge sequences and a curriculum that integrates English, history, literature, and the classics, with a high school program featuring topics such as The Classical World, European History, and U.S. History in honors tracks, consistent with a classical canon and Great Conversation approach .
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, Latin, classical literature, classical canon, historical breadth across Western civilization, integration of history with literature, and the “classical liberal arts curriculum” framing .
- Negative: Some elements reflect modern pedagogy (e.g., Direct Instruction, Saxon Math) that are less emblematic of strict classical pedagogy; however, these are presented within a broader classical frame, so they do not overwhelm the classical orientation in the public materials.
- Why this rating
- The school’s curriculum is explicitly described as classical and liberal-arts–driven, with explicit Latin study, classical literature, and honors offerings tied to a Great Books culture. This robust alignment with the classical curriculum criteria justifies CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Pedagogical language includes CHAMPs discipline approach in elementary classrooms, which emphasizes structure, memory, and positive classroom behavior; this reflects a traditional approach to order and virtue in schooling.
- Public materials show a mix of methods: direct instruction in foundational content (Core Knowledge, Saxon Math, Reading Mastery) alongside classical elements such as literature study and Latin, and the use of memorization/recitation via writing programs (Writing with Ease/Skill) and Shurley Grammar;

higher grades hint at more discussion and rhetoric through honors classical coursework, but explicit Socratic seminars are not consistently described in public pages ,.

- The presence of “Honors The Classical World,” classical literature and the Latin track signals engagement with rhetoric and classical dialogue traditions, though explicit descriptions of Socratic seminars or Paideia-style discussion are not consistently documented in the public materials ,.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: CHAMPs discipline; memorization/recitation; classical literature; Latin; writing in imitation (Shurley/recitation-based practice); a restful/ contemplative cadence is implied in the public mission though not always explicit (Scholé appears in classical lexicons rather than in Vanguard’s pages) ,.
- Negative: reliance on direct instruction and some modern programs (Direct Instruction, Saxon Math) that diverge from strict, memory-based classical pedagogy; limited explicit evidence of Socratic seminars on the public pages (which are a hallmark of higher-grade classical pedagogy).
- Why this rating
- The Vanguard School demonstrates strong classical elements (memory work, recitation traditions, Latin, Great Books orientation) but also uses modern instructional approaches in parts of its program. The blend yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for this category rather than a pure CLASSICAL categorization.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials describe the faculty as virtuous and academically grounded, with teachers serving as mentors and exemplars; the school emphasizes the faculty as the living curriculum and a core of the school community (e.g., “teachers are highly qualified,” “mentors,” “living curriculum,” “portrait of what a teacher should be”) ,.
- The school emphasizes mentorship and parent-teacher engagement, with regular conferences and ongoing faculty accessibility, indicating a collegial, mentorship-focused faculty culture ,.
- Public statements frame faculty as guides and exemplars committed to virtue and excellence, with leadership and civics as part of the school’s core mission.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: living curriculum, faculty of friends, mentorship, virtue and mastery, high qualifications, teacher accessibility, collegiality (present in multiple pages) ,.
- Negative: no explicit negative signals regarding faculty practice in public pages; no strong negative indicators present.
- Why this rating
- The school presents a robust, virtue-led faculty culture with mentorship, high qualifications, and a central role of teachers as exemplars, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The Vanguard School publicly states that parental involvement is encouraged in virtually every aspect of the school and that parents’ values at home align with the school’s curriculum (parents as co-educators).
- The site emphasizes partnerships with families and ongoing opportunities for parent formation via the website, meetings, and events; parents are welcome for campus visits and engagement with the school community.
- The school communicates a culture of community involvement, transparency, and shared mission between families, teachers, and administrators (e.g., annual fund, events, and community partnerships).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, parental engagement, open campus, community partnerships, family involvement, classical home-education language (where relevant) ,.
- Negative: none evident in public-facing materials; no evidence of a consumer-only or passive parental role.

- Why this rating
- The school emphasizes strong parent involvement, parent education, and a campus that is welcoming to families, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL.
- Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL
- Rationale: The school demonstrates robust classical alignment in Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community, with clear formation-focused aims in School Purpose and Goal. Pedagogy and Religious/Metaphysical Foundations show strong classical elements but include modern instructional practices and lack explicit theological or liturgical language; thus Element 4 and Element 1 are only SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The aggregate across all six categories yields CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- For a CLASSICAL rating with all six categories, specific enhancements could further strengthen the assessment:
- Make theological/metaphysical foundations explicit in public materials (e.g., articulate transcendental aims or explicit incorporation of theology in curriculum) to elevate Element 1 to CLASSICAL.
- Increase explicit documentation of Socratic or Paideia-style pedagogy in high-school materials (e.g., described seminars, debates, and regular great-conversation-style discussions) to strengthen Element 4 toward CLASSICAL.
- Highlight Great Books dialogue and primary-source engagement as a regular, visible practice across grade levels, reinforcing Element 3 with stronger explicit references to Great Books and the Great Conversation.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.